



The original 1903 airplane designed by Wilbur and Orville Wright makes its first flight on December 17, 1903 in Kitty Hawk, North Carolina.

TWO BROTHERS IN THE US, WILBUR (1867–1912) AND ORVILLE (1871–1948) WRIGHT, became obsessed with the growing science of aviation and were determined to fly. They pumped the profits from their bicycle shop into their experiments and built a biplane. In the town of Kitty Hawk, on the coast of North Carolina, they began to conduct experiments. On the morning of December 17, their work paid off when Orville made what is considered to be the **first successful flight** in an airplane that the pilot had complete control over (as opposed to earlier attempts with gliders). He traveled 197 ft (60 m) in 12 seconds. Later that day Wilbur flew 850 ft (259 m) in 59 seconds.

Farther south, in **Panama**, the US had resurrected the idea of building a canal between the Atlantic and Pacific, the first attempt at which had failed more



Lion in the path
The United States publication Judge depicts the Panama Canal as the "lion in the path" in this political cartoon.

however, were intertwined with the infamous **Dreyfus Affair**. This was a scandal involving Alfred Dreyfus (1859–1935), a French officer who was accused of treason. Evidence came to light that cleared Dreyfus, but it was suppressed. Dreyfus was Jewish, and France

than a decade before (see 1889). The US wanted to purchase the assets of the former French holding company and begin construction, but talks with the **Colombian** government (which still controlled the isthmus) broke down. Soon after, in 1903, Panama, with the backing of the US, declared its **independence**. By 1904, Panama and the US had agreed on the terms of the Panama Canal Zone, in which the US would be permitted to exercise its jurisdiction until 1979, and work on the canal began.

In **France**, cyclist Henri Desgrange (1865–1940) organized a race that would become one of the most prestigious in the world: the **Tour de France**. Its roots,

became divided over the issue of **anti-Semitism**. During the scandal, the sports newspaper *Le Vélo* supported Dreyfus. Angry advertisers decided to set up a rival periodical, *L'Auto-Vélo*, later called *L'Auto*. Cycling promoter Desgrange was hired as editor. However, *L'Auto*'s sales were initially poor, and so a race was organized to promote it. Desgrange devised a month-long cycling contest (though it was later shortened) which followed the route of Paris–Lyon–Marseille–Toulouse–Bordeaux–Nantes–Paris. On July 1, 60 competitors set off. The event's first winner was Maurice Garin.

12 SECONDS

THE DURATION OF THE WRIGHT BROTHERS' FIRST FLIGHT



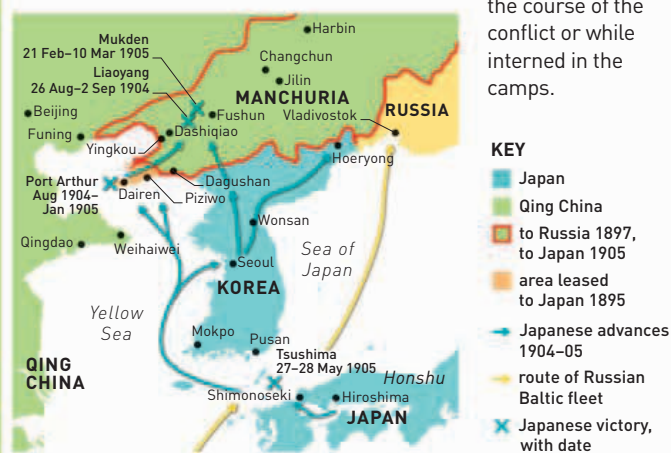
The French newspaper *Petit Journal* shows how the Russian sick and wounded were transported on skis during the Russo–Japanese war.

JAPAN AND RUSSIA HAD BEEN COMPETING to expand their influence in Manchuria and Korea. Russia had built its Trans-Siberian railroad (see 1891), which now had a line running into **Manchuria**, annexed during the Boxer crisis in China (see 1900). During this time, **Japan** had begun to build up its army and navy, and approached Russia in 1903 to suggest they recognize each other's mutual interests in these regions. The talks broke down on February 6, 1904, and three days later Japan attacked Russian warships, sinking two of them and triggering the **Russo–Japanese War**. Japan then sent troops into Manchuria and Korea, forcing the Russians farther north over the course of

the year. A peace deal was brokered by US President Theodore Roosevelt (1858–1919), and on September 5 a treaty was signed that forced Russia to leave Manchuria, cede part of the island of **Sakhalin** to Japan, and recognize Japan's interests in **Korea**, as well as grant fishing rights off the coast of Siberia. Japan's victory against Russia marked its emergence as a major world power.

In Africa, German troops were facing rebellions in their colonies. Revolts broke out in **German South West Africa** (Namibia), where the **Khoikhoi** people had risen up in 1903, followed by the **Herero** in 1904. Many Africans were rounded up and put into concentration camps, where the work conditions were so dire that more than half of the prisoners died. By the time Germany had suppressed the rebellion, in 1908, about 80 percent of the Herero and 50 percent of the Khoikhoi peoples had been killed, either in

Russo–Japanese War
This map shows the course of the conflict in which a victorious Japan drove Russia out of Manchuria, forcing Russia to give up its expansionist policy in East Asia.



the course of the conflict or while interned in the camps.

June 11 Serbia's King Alexander Obrenović (b. 1876) and Queen Draga (b. 1864) are assassinated

September 29 Prussia is first to require drivers' licenses for automobiles

November 18 Deal signed between US and Colombia to start on **Panama Canal** (canal opens in 1914)

November 4 Panama declares independence from Colombia with US backing

December 17 Inventor brothers Orville and Wilbur Wright make first flight at Kitty Hawk, North Carolina

February 8 Russo–Japanese War (to 1905) begins when Japan sinks two Russian warships

May 9 The City of Truro becomes the first locomotive to exceed 100 mph, traveling from Plymouth to London, England

October 21 Russo–Japanese War: Dogger Bank incident in which Russian fleet accidentally fires on British trawlers in North Sea

January 12 Herero Rebellion in German South West Africa begins

April 8 Britain and France sign Entente Cordiale paving way for peaceful relations ever since